<u>Why Honors?</u>

By Joel Tchouke

Looking across all of these experiences, I now see how the Honors competencies overlap. Leadership often required intercultural awareness when working with diverse groups of students. Research required teamwork, communication, and the ability to learn from others. Intercultural engagement often involved leadership as well, whether helping international students adapt to campus life or organizing cultural events that brought communities together. These experiences were not isolated from one another; they constantly influenced and reinforced each other.

When I first joined the Honors Program and took HONR 201, my understanding of leadership, research, and intercultural engagement was very basic. At that time, I saw these competencies as separate boxes that needed to be checked. Leadership meant holding positions in organizations. Research meant working on technical projects. Intercultural engagement meant interacting with people from different backgrounds. Over time, however, my experiences throughout college showed me that these areas are deeply connected, often appearing together rather than separately. Looking back now, the Honors Program has shaped not only what I have done in college, but also how I understand and connect my experiences.

One of the earliest experiences that helped me understand this connection was my work as a MavPASS leader. In that role, I facilitated collaborative learning sessions for Electrical Engineering students and later served as a Peer Mentor supporting other leaders. While this experience strengthened my leadership skills, it also required a strong awareness of different student backgrounds, learning styles, and levels of confidence. Some students were more comfortable speaking up, while others needed encouragement to participate. This showed me that leadership is not simply about directing others, but about understanding people and adapting to them. Leadership, in this context, naturally required intercultural awareness, even in an academic setting.

This connection became even more clear through my leadership roles in the African Student Association and the International Student Association. As Vice President, I helped coordinate events such as African Night and the International Festival, where students from many different cultural backgrounds came together. These experiences required more than organization; they required navigating cultural differences, balancing perspectives, and ensuring that everyone felt represented. Through this, I realized that leadership and intercultural engagement are often inseparable when working in diverse communities.

My involvement in technical organizations provided another perspective on how these competencies overlap. As President of the Cybersecurity Association and Treasurer of IEEE, I worked with teams to organize technical events, prepare students for competitions, and coordinate travel to conferences like IEEE Rising Stars. These experiences showed me that leadership in technical spaces is not just about managing tasks, but about building environments where people can learn from each other. This same idea extended directly into my research experiences.

One of my earliest research projects, working with Professor Winstead to improve the power efficiency of a LEGO robotics brick, taught me that research is inherently collaborative. Although the work involved technical design, circuit development, and testing using tools such as KiCad and MATLAB, progress depended heavily on communication, shared problem-solving, and learning from failure. Many of our early attempts did not succeed, but those moments forced us to analyze our approach more deeply and refine our ideas together.

Through this experience, I learned that research is not a straightforward process, but a cycle of experimentation that relies on teamwork and persistence.

This understanding expanded further through the Smart Glasses Accessibility Project. The project required collaboration across multiple engineering areas, including artificial intelligence, embedded systems, and wireless communication. Working within a team meant constantly aligning ideas, integrating different components, and adapting to each other's progress. At the same time, the purpose of the project, improving accessibility through object recognition and text-to-speech, introduced a broader perspective. It made me consider how individuals with different needs interact with technology, adding a human and intercultural dimension to the research. This experience showed me that technical work is not only about functionality, but also about understanding the people it is meant to serve.

My senior design project with Taylor Corporation reinforced these ideas in a professional context. Unlike earlier academic projects, this experience involved working with real industrial systems where our decisions could affect manufacturing processes. The project required redesigning and modernizing a poly exposure control system using electrical schematics and PLC logic. Throughout this process, we worked closely with professional engineers, received feedback, and iterated on our designs. This showed me that research in a real-world environment depends not only on technical knowledge, but also on communication, collaboration, and the ability to adapt based on input from others.

Intercultural engagement was not separate from these experiences; it shaped how I approached them. When I first arrived in the United States from Cameroon, I had to adapt to a new language, culture, and educational environment. My time in the Intensive English Program helped me understand how closely language and culture are connected, and how communication can influence confidence and participation. This experience made me more aware of the challenges that come with navigating unfamiliar environments.

Later, as a Maverick Global Ambassador, I found myself taking on a leadership role while supporting other international students. Whether helping them adjust to campus life or participating in events such as the International Festival, I was not only engaging with different cultures but also guiding others through similar transitions. This reinforced my understanding that intercultural engagement often involves leadership, especially when shared experiences allow you to support others more effectively.

My understanding of the Honors competencies has changed significantly since HONR 201. Early in the program, I focused on completing activities and meeting requirements. Over time, I began to see the importance of reflection. Instead of simply asking whether I had participated in an experience, I began asking what I had learned and how those experiences connected. This shift allowed me to move beyond participation and toward a deeper level of personal and intellectual growth.

If I had not participated in the Honors Program, my college experience would likely have looked very different. I might still have joined organizations, worked on research projects, and interacted with students from different backgrounds. However, I would not have taken the time to reflect on how these experiences connect or what they taught me about myself. The Honors Program encouraged me to step back, analyze my experiences, and understand how they contributed to my development.

In the end, the Honors Program transformed my college journey from a series of separate activities into a connected learning process. Through leadership, research, and intercultural engagement, I developed stronger critical thinking skills, greater self-awareness, and a clearer sense of purpose. This portfolio represents not only the work I have completed, but also the growth that occurred along the way and the perspective I will continue to carry forward